

Why do we feel embarrassed for other people?

Section1: My Initial Thoughts & Guesses

Prompts:

- When have I felt second-hand embarrassment?
- Do I look away? Laugh? Freeze?
- Do I feel it more for strangers or people I know?
- Does everyone around me react the same?

When people do something that pulls a lot of attention onto them, not in a good way, that's when I feel second-hand embarrassment. So I usually look away, partly so they don't catch me watching, and partly because I don't want to add to the embarrassment.

Sometimes, people do things they aren't embarrassed about at all, yet others feel embarrassed on their behalf. In those moments, I try to neutral or even reassure them by saying they're doing great. At the end of the day, who am I to judge? If they're comfortable being themselves, that's not something I want to shut down.

I feel this feeling much more strongly for people I know. With them, I feel like I'm indirectly part of the embarrassment, especially since they might later talk to me about it. I also know them well enough to understand what would embarrass them and what wouldn't, which makes the feeling more intense.

With strangers, it's different. I don't know what's a big deal for them, how they'll process the situation, or how they'll move on afterward. So while I might still feel second-hand embarrassment, it's less intense. There's a distance there; I don't know their story.

And I don't think everyone reacts the same way. Some people judge, some point it out, some join in and laugh, and others ignore it completely. Everyone has their own way of dealing with these moments, and mine just happens to be quiet empathy.

Prompts:

- Why do I think this feeling exists?
- Is it empathy, fear, social rules, or self-projection?
- Does it feel learned or instinctive?
- Why does it feel uncomfortable rather than neutral?

I think this feeling of embarrassment exists because we tend to judge people, and from that judgment, the feeling evolves. Not necessarily in a bad way. We also judge ourselves, and I feel that this self-judgment gets projected outward, which results in second-hand embarrassment. Another reason is that we often see ourselves in others. We project our beliefs onto them, and we feel embarrassed on their behalf.

Sometimes, the feeling comes from sympathy. Sometimes, we simply feel embarrassed because, as humans, we tend to sympathize deeply. I also think social norms play a major role. We follow societal rules so automatically that we forget to question our own actions and the actions of others. This leads to judging and defining situations in ways we might not personally believe in, but still react to because "that's how it's supposed to be."

Regarding whether this feeling is learned or instinctive, I feel it is partly instinctive and cannot be fully taught. It happens unconsciously, and only later do we question why we felt that way. Embarrassment feels more automatic.

I think it feels uncomfortable because we see ourselves in the situation and imagine how we would react if we were there, which makes the experience emotionally uneasy rather than neutral.

Question Creation + Light Research

Section 2: Questions I Want Answers To and some Notes

These are the questions I need answers to:

1. What is second-hand embarrassment?

Vicarious embarrassment is when you personally experience embarrassment, discomfort, shame, or guilt whenever you witness someone else have an experience that's particularly embarrassing or causes them to be viewed negatively. [3]

2. Is second-hand embarrassment a good thing or bad?

For our nervous system it mostly treats it like a negative trait and sth that has to be avoided. However, it is generally good to have some capacity for it as it shows healthy empathy, but too much can be draining.

3. If empathy is related to second-hand embarrassment, then do you think psychopath does not feel this emotion?

Typically, there are two types of empathy:

Cognitive empathy: Understanding what someone feels (just acknowledging it)

Affective empathy: Actually feeling what someone feels (eg, crying when you hear someone else's dog dies or sth like that; experience their emotion)

And typically, there are two types of psychopaths

Primary psychopath: born this way, genetic/neurological; emotionally cold

Secondary psychopath: developed from the environment, likely trauma, abuse, or neglect

So, to answer the question, as per the article from Frontiers[1], the primary psychopath lacks both types of empathy, but the secondary psychopath feels enhanced cognitive empathy but lacks affective empathy. This can help them manipulate others and learn more about their victims. Hence, as the psychopath does not feel affective empathy at all, which you have to feel to feel second-hand embarrassment, they don't feel any second-hand embarrassment for others at all. This can be backed up by an article from Psychology Today[2] as well.

4. The relation between empathy, sympathy, and second-hand embarrassment?

Empathy = putting yourself in their situation and feeling what they feel

Sympathy and **second-hand embarrassment** are both subsets - they're specific applications of that empathic ability:

- **Sympathy:** You empathize with someone's suffering and feel concern/pity for them
- **Second-hand embarrassment:** You empathize with someone's embarrassment and feel that cringe yourself

Both require that fundamental empathic capacity to imagine yourself in their position and connect with their emotional state. The difference is just which emotion you're tuning into and how you respond to it. So yeah, they're both branches of the same tree.

5. Difference between cringe and second-hand embarrassment?

Pure **second-hand embarrassment (empathy-based)**:

- You feel bad *for* the person
- You're imagining yourself in their situation
- It's uncomfortable because you genuinely empathize with their pain
- Example: Your friend's voice cracks during a presentation - you feel their pain

"Cringe" (often involves mockery/superiority):

- You feel uncomfortable but also kind of... superior?
- There's judgment mixed in - "wow, they're so awkward."
- You're distancing yourself from them, not identifying with them
- Example: Watching "cringe compilations" on YouTube for entertainment

Note :

Source: Reddit and Claude

- cause Empathy; cause mirror neurons, we see in them

Further in mirror neurons

- Second-hand embarrassment is also known as vicarious embarrassment.
- Mirror neuron was studied in association with chimpanzees/monkeys, and we don't have much evidence for humans yet. So this is highly controversial and mostly hype.
- What mirror neurons supposedly are: Brain cells that fire both when you do something AND when you watch someone else do it.
- The **claimed connection to second-hand embarrassment**: When you see someone embarrass themselves, your mirror neurons supposedly fire as if YOU'RE the one being embarrassed, making you feel the cringe.

Secondhand embarrassment can be measured, even though it's a subjective feeling; researchers can measure it both through what people report feeling AND through objective body/brain responses. That's actually how they proved the link between empathy and second-hand embarrassment - people who scored higher on empathy tests also showed stronger reactions (both self-reported and physiological) to embarrassing scenarios.

What is actually proven about second-hand embarrassment:

1. It exists and is measurable
2. It is linked to empathy
3. Specific brain regions are involved like ACC and anterior insula; these are the same areas involved in processing pain and negative emotions

What we don't know:

1. the exact neural mechanism (how it works at the cellular level)
2. Whether mirror neurons specifically cause it
3. Why do some people feel it more intensely than others?

Section 3: Comparison

Where I Was RIGHT:

We project ourselves onto others (affective empathy). Social norms drive it. It's automatic/instinctive. It's uncomfortable because we imagine being in their situation. Everyone reacts differently

Where I Was PARTIALLY Right:

Judgment: I thought judgment causes it, but research shows it's empathy-based. Judgment is more part of "cringe culture," not true second-hand embarrassment. Sympathy: Related to second-hand embarrassment but different - sympathy = pity/concern, second-hand embarrassment = actually feeling their embarrassment.

What I MISSED:

Cognitive vs. Affective Empathy: Didn't know there were two types. Psychopaths don't feel it: They lack affective empathy, so no second-hand embarrassment. Brain regions involved: ACC and anterior insula light up. It's measurable: Through brain scans, physical responses, and self-reports. Mirror neurons are overhyped: Controversial, mostly studied in monkeys

New Angles:

"Cringe" ≠ second-hand embarrassment - Cringe often involves mockery/superiority; true second-hand embarrassment is pure empathy. Psychopathy connection - Primary psychopaths lack both empathy types; secondary psychopaths have cognitive but no affective (perfect for manipulation). The nervous system treats it as a threat - Designed to teach us what NOT to do socially

Section 4: What other thinks

- We feel it cause of empathy. (1)
- this is sth that is instinctive (2)

Key Growth:

My instincts were right about mechanics (projection, social norms, automatic response), but I lacked the scientific framework. Biggest insight: **empathy-based embarrassment** (feeling bad FOR them) ≠ **judgment-based cringe** (feeling superior TO them).

References:

1. <https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2023.1082965/full>
2. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/basics/embarrassment?msocid=258d1abc2d0e636932c40c4b2c8c62e9>
3. <https://health.clevelandclinic.org/second-hand-embarrassment>